

Downing sworn in to Anniston City Council

By Bill Wilson, Star Staff Writer, wwilson@annistonstar.com

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Lewis Downing was sworn in as Ward 1 councilman Thursday night during a special session of the Anniston City Council. Downing was appointed to the vacant seat last week to fill the unexpired term of Jay Jenkins, who stepped down from the council in October.

Calhoun County Probate Judge Alice Martin swore in Downing, who was accompanied by his wife, Katie, and his three children, Hannah, Luke and Lillie. Downing will serve until municipal elections in August at which time he can run for the office.

There was not an empty seat in the council chambers as well-wishers, city officials and family gathered for the short ceremony. After he was sworn in, Downing's first official act as a councilman was to make a motion to adjourn the meeting.



Lewis Downing smiles after being sworn in during a special session of the Anniston city council Thursday night. Photo by Bill Wilson, The Anniston

Downing — who owns Downing & Sons in downtown Anniston — said he's ready to get to work.

"I've got a ton of confidence right now. I'm eager to get to work and see what we can do for Anniston," Downing said. "I'm excited more than anything."

He expressed gratitude for the support shown at the ceremony.

"It gives me so much encouragement and makes me feel so good, gives me so much confidence that we can really get to work and tackle these issues that we need to continue to move Anniston forward," he said.

During the ceremony, Downing's father, Robert, beamed with pride as he watched his son take the oath of office. The elder Downing served as a Calhoun County commissioner for 16 years, from 1994 to 2010.

"I'm so proud that Lewis has taken this responsibility and is going to work hard. He loves this city and I'm proud for him, and I'm hopeful for the future of the city, and all the things that can be done here," Robert Downing said.

"Anniston is a wonderful place to grow up, to live, to work, and I think Lewis will be a good addition to this council. It's been a great council to work with, and just a special moment as a father to see your son have this honor and the responsibility that comes with it. I'm looking forward to the future," he added.

Downing placed his hand on his family's well-worn Bible during the ceremony, which was held by his wife.

Robert explained the Bible's special significance to the family.

"This is my grandmother Downing's Bible. Don't know exactly how old it is. I think it dates to the early '20s, and it's been passed through the family for a long time. It's the Bible that I was sworn in on when I was elected to the Calhoun County Commission, and so proud that Lewis is able to use it tonight," he said.

After the meeting, Mayor Jack Draper said he expects Downing to do a "great job."

"He's a great guy with a good personality, conscientious, so we all look forward to working with him, and he will be a great addition to the Anniston City Council," Draper said.

Main Street Anniston Executive Director Karla Eden was in attendance and said she looks forward to collaborating with Downing to strengthen the community.

“It’s exciting to see one of our downtown business owners, whose roots are deeply planted in the Anniston community, stepping up to serve on the City Council. As someone who understands the heartbeat of our downtown, his leadership will bring a unique perspective that will help drive progress for our city,” Eden said.

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